

The Mobile PT Manifesto

*How to Escape the Gym Rent Trap and Build a
Profitable London Fitness Business*

By Dean Burt

*For every PT standing on a gym floor at 11 PM,
mopping equipment they don't own,
in a building that owns them.*

This one's for you.

Disclaimer: *This book contains real advice based on real experience running a mobile PT business in London. It is not a get-rich-quick guide. It requires work, consistency, and the willingness to train in the rain when everyone else goes home. If you are looking for easy answers, you are in the wrong place.*

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Prologue: 6:02 AM on a Tuesday in November

It is raining.

Not drizzling. Not "a bit damp." It is raining the way London rains when it means it — sideways, cold, the kind of rain that finds the gap between your collar and your neck within thirty seconds of stepping outside.

I am on my e-bike, crossing a park in East London, at six in the morning.

My phone shows three messages.

The first is from a trainer I know. He works a gym floor on the other side of the city. *"This weather is mad. I'm staying in. You out today?"*

The second is from another PT in my old WhatsApp group — trainers I met during my Level 3. *"No way I'm doing outdoor sessions today. Called them all."*

The third is from my 6:00 AM client, Sarah. It came in at 5:48 AM.

"On my way. Ready to go!"

I arrive at the park, lock the bike, pull the mat out of the rack bag, and we get started. The session is forty-five minutes. Sarah does not stop smiling the whole way through. Not because the weather is good — it isn't. Because nobody else is here. Because she is doing something that most people won't. Because *I* showed up when most trainers didn't, and that means something to her.

At 6:47 AM, the session ends. Sarah transfers the money before she even gets to her car.

I have another client at 7:15 AM. Different park. Seven minutes on the bike.

By 9:00 AM, I have completed three sessions and earned more than some PTs will earn today at the gym they commute forty-five minutes to reach, where they will spend most of their shift not training anyone.

Those trainers are not lazy. They are not bad at their job.

They are trapped in the wrong model.

This book is about getting out of it.

I want to be clear about something from the start.

I am not going to tell you that building a mobile PT business in London is easy. It isn't. The early mornings are real. The weather is real. The moments of self-doubt — when you have two clients and you wonder if you have made a terrible mistake — those are real too.

What I am going to tell you is that it is *possible*. Not theoretically possible. Actually, concretely, financially demonstrably possible. Because I have done it. And I have watched other trainers do it. And I have watched the trainers who went the gym chain route spend years running in place before they either burned out or finally made the same move I am telling you to make right now.

The fitness industry in London has a dirty secret.

The business model that most new trainers are sold into — the gym floor role, the "build your client base here" pitch, the rent-clawback contract — is not designed to help you succeed. It is designed to extract your time and your labour at the lowest possible cost, while keeping you just comfortable enough to stay.

This book is about understanding that trap, escaping it, and building something real.

Let's start at the beginning.

Chapter One — The Gym Group Trap

How the UK's biggest gym chains turned personal trainers into unpaid staff

The Pitch

You have just qualified.

You have your Level 3 Personal Training certificate. You have spent four months studying anatomy, programming, nutrition fundamentals, and client communication. You are ready. You are excited. You know that the first step is getting in front of clients, and the fastest way to get in front of clients is to go where the clients already are.

A big gym chain. The Gym Group. PureGym. Anytime Fitness. One of the nationals.

You walk in. You speak to the manager. And they give you the pitch.

"We'd love to have you on the floor. Great community here. Loads of footfall. Members are always looking for PTs. You'll build your client base really quickly. And in terms of your li-

cence, it's very reasonable — £X per month. You'll make that back in your first week once you're up and running."

It sounds good.

It sounds like an opportunity.

Here is what they do not tell you.

The Reality of the Gym Floor

You start on Monday.

You are told to be there at 6:00 AM because the gym opens at 6:00 AM and there will be members coming in who might be interested in PT.

You stand at the desk. Or you walk the floor. Or you make yourself look busy doing "consultations" that amount to asking people how long they have been members and whether they have ever considered working with a trainer.

Most people say no, not right now, thanks.

Some people say maybe.

One person says yes, and you schedule an intro session.

By 9:00 AM, the morning rush is over. The manager comes over.

"Can you do a quick clean of the equipment in the free weights section? We're short-staffed this morning."

You do it. Because you want to be helpful. Because you are new and you do not want to make waves. Because they implied, without quite saying it, that being a good member of the team would help you get referrals.

At 11:00 AM, you do a session with the one client you have.

At 12:30 PM, you stand on the floor again.

At 2:00 PM, you are asked to help with a new member induction because the fitness manager is on lunch.

At 4:00 PM, the after-work rush starts. You do another floor walk. You have some conversations. Nobody signs up.

At 7:30 PM, the rush dies down. You have been in the building for thirteen and a half hours. You have completed one paid session. The rest of your time — over twelve hours of it — has been unpaid.

You go home. You are exhausted. You tell yourself it will get better.

Sometimes it does, a little. Mostly, it does not.

The Rent Clawback Model — Explained Clearly

Here is the mechanism that most PTs do not fully understand until they have experienced it personally, by which point they have usually lost significant money.

The gym charges you a monthly licence fee. Let's say £350 per month. This is the fee for the right to train clients on their floor.

In many contracts — read yours *very* carefully — there is a clause. It goes something like this:

"Where the trainer's monthly PT session income falls below the licence fee threshold, the shortfall will be deducted from the trainer's session earnings."

What that means in plain English: if you don't earn enough to cover your rent, they take the rest of your money to make up the difference.

Let's run the numbers.

In your first month, you have three clients. You do eight sessions. Your rate is £45/session. That is £360.

Your licence fee is £350.

You keep £10.

Ten pounds. For a month of work.

Now extend that scenario. You have been there for three months. You have five clients. You are doing eighteen sessions per month. $£45 \times 18 = £810$. Minus £350 licence. You keep £460.

That sounds better. But you have worked every weekday for three months. You have done floor shifts. You have cleaned equipment. You have done member inductions. You have attended mandatory training sessions. If you divide your actual income by the hours you have spent in that building, you are making somewhere in the region of £3–£4 an hour.

A cleaner in London earns more than that.

And a cleaner gets paid for every hour they work.

The 12-Hour Shift

This is the part that nobody talks about openly because it reflects badly on an industry that is supposed to be about helping people and building careers.

The gym benefits enormously from having PTs on the floor.

You are free labour. You make the gym look staffed. You interact with members, which improves the member experience, which drives retention, which generates revenue for the gym. You answer questions, you do inductions, you provide a visible fitness presence.

You do all of this without the gym paying you a single penny.

They frame it as your opportunity. In reality, it is their subsidy.

The trainers who do well in this environment — the ones who genuinely build strong client bases and eventually earn decent money on a gym floor — are the ones who are extraordinary at sales. Not at training. At sales. Because the gym floor is not a training environment. It is a sales floor. And if selling is not your primary skill set, you will spend years being a free resource for a corporation while earning very little for yourself.

The Other Costs Nobody Mentions

Beyond the licence fee and the unpaid hours, there are costs that accumulate silently.

Travel. Most PTs do not live near the gym they work at. A Zone 1-2 commute on the tube costs £160–£200 per month. Add that to your licence fee and your break-even point just went up.

Your hours are not yours. When the gym decides they want you there at a specific time, you are there. You cannot schedule a morning client elsewhere and come in at noon. Your entire schedule is dictated by the gym's floor rota, not by what makes sense for your business.

The non-compete grey area. Some contracts include language that restricts you from training the gym's members in any other context — even after you leave. Read that clause.

Understand it. The members you build relationships with inside that building are, in many gyms' interpretation, *their* clients, not yours.

The brand problem. You are building a client base associated with a specific location. The gym. If you leave — voluntarily or otherwise — a significant portion of those clients stay. Not because they prefer the gym to you, but because of inertia, because the location is convenient, because finding you outside the gym requires more effort than they are willing to make without a push.

Who the Gym Floor Actually Works For

I want to be honest here, because some trainers will read this and think I am being unfair to the gym chains.

The gym floor model is not useless.

For a newly qualified trainer with zero clients, zero reviews, and no idea how to generate their own leads, the gym floor provides one genuinely valuable thing: a stream of people who are already thinking about fitness.

If you walk into a gym floor role with a specific, disciplined strategy — *I am going to be here for ninety days. I am going to convert five direct clients. I am going to collect five reviews. Then I*

am leaving — you can extract value from the experience without being consumed by it.

The trainers who get stuck are the ones who walk in without that exit plan. Who allow the "it's getting better" narrative to keep them there for twelve, eighteen, twenty-four months. Who structure their entire financial life around the gym floor income and then find it impossible to leave because the disruption feels too large.

Getting Out

If you are currently on a gym floor and reading this, the question is not whether to leave. It is when, and how.

When: When you have at least five paying clients outside the gym context, or a credible plan to acquire them within sixty days of leaving. Not three. Not two. Five. Five clients at £45 a session, three sessions each per month, is £675. That is not a living wage, but it is a foundation you can build from without panicking.

How: You do not burn bridges. You do not bad-mouth the gym on your way out. You leave professionally, with notice, with your client contacts secured (within the terms of your contract), and with your reviews and reputation intact. You are going to need word-of-mouth referrals. Word-of-mouth requires goodwill.

The Mindset Shift

Here is the thing about the gym trap that makes it psychologically difficult to escape, even when you intellectually understand it:

It feels safe.

You go in at a specific time. You know where you are. There are other people around. The structure of someone else's business provides a scaffold for your day. When you leave and become fully mobile, fully independent, that scaffold disappears. The responsibility is entirely yours.

That is uncomfortable.

It is also exactly what you signed up for when you became a personal trainer rather than an employee.

The discomfort of independence is temporary. The discomfort of the gym trap — the financial ceiling, the unpaid hours, the slow erosion of your ambition — is permanent unless you choose to change it.

Chapter One Summary: The big gym chain model extracts your time, caps your income, and keeps you financially dependent through rent-clawback contracts and unpaid floor hours. It is not a career. It is a holding pattern with a monthly fee. Get out with a plan, not an impulse.

Chapter Two — The London-Proof Strategy

How to build a business that works in any weather, any borough, any season

The Outdoor Advantage

There is a reason the best mobile PTs in London are not trying to rent studio space or negotiate gym partnerships.

London is a city of parks.

Hyde Park. Victoria Park. Clapham Common. Hackney Marshes. Hampstead Heath. Battersea Park. The Heath Extension. The parks that run along the Lea Valley. The small local parks in every residential borough that almost nobody visits before 7:00 AM but are perfectly maintained and completely free to use.

The outdoor training model is not a compromise. It is not the option you choose because you cannot afford a studio. It is, when done correctly, a *superior* offering — in experience, in results, in client retention, and in margin.

Here is why.

No rent. No hire fee. No minimum hours. No booking system to manage. No other clients interrupting your session. No fluorescent lighting. No music that isn't yours. No commute to a fixed location on someone else's schedule.

Your office is a park. And in London, your office is everywhere.

But to make this work — properly, consistently, profitably — you need three things:

A logistics system that lets you move between clients without burning time or money.

A mindset that treats weather as irrelevant.

A map of where you can and cannot legally work.

Let's cover all three.

Part One: The E-Bike Logistics Strategy

The Most Profitable Business Decision You Will Make This Year

New PTs entering the mobile market make the same mistake every time.

They think about transport the way they think about personal life transport — the way it feels, the status of it, the comfort. They imagine themselves arriving at a client's park in a car, looking professional.

Then they spend the first six months learning what mobile PT transport actually requires:

- Speed over short distances (1–5 miles)
- Reliability regardless of traffic
- Zero parking cost
- Zero parking time
- Zero congestion charge
- The ability to carry full kit

No car delivers all five. No motorcycle delivers all five. Public transport delivers none of them reliably.

An e-bike delivers all five.

Let me show you the numbers.

The Cost Comparison

	Car	Motorcycle	Public Transport	E-Bike
Insurance	£150– £300/mo	£80– £200/mo	—	£10– £15/mo
Fuel/Charge	£120– £200/mo	£60– £100/mo	—	£2– £5/mo
Parking	£80– £300/mo	£30– £80/mo	—	£0
Congestion Charge	£0– £300/mo	£0– £300/mo	—	£0
Fines (average)	£40– £120/mo	£20– £80/mo	—	£0
Monthly Oyster	—	—	£180– £250	£0–£40
Total monthly	£390– £1,220	£190–£760	£180– £250	£12– £60

The gap between the cheapest car option and an e-bike is approximately £330 per month at minimum. At the higher end of the car cost range, it is over £1,100 per month.

That is, at minimum, seven sessions per month that you are working purely to cover the cost of your transport.

But the financial case, as dramatic as it is, is not even the main argument for the e-bike.

The main argument is time.

The Time Argument

A typical mobile PT working morning slots in London might have clients in two or three different locations within a 3–5 mile radius.

On an e-bike, 3 miles in London at 6:00 AM takes approximately 12–15 minutes. Every time. Regardless of traffic. Regardless of roadworks. Regardless of anything.

In a car at 7:30 AM — even in London's "quiet" pre-rush period — the same 3 miles takes 20–40 minutes, depending on the route and the day. During peak hours, it can take longer.

Here is what that time difference means in practice.

Without an e-bike (car or public transport):

- 5:30 AM session ends at 6:15 AM
- Travel to next client: 30 minutes
- Next session at 6:45 AM — starts rushed, you arrive at 6:43

In practice, you cannot reliably fit a 6:45 AM slot. You push it to 7:00 AM. Which means your morning finishes at 7:45 AM. Three slots maximum, with generous gaps.

With an e-bike:

- 5:30 AM session ends at 6:15 AM
- Travel to next client: 13 minutes
- 6:30 AM session starts on time
- Travel to third client: 12 minutes
- 7:30 AM session starts on time

Three tight, professional, well-paced sessions by 8:15 AM. No rushing. No stress. No late apologies.

At £50 a session, that is £150 by 8:15 AM.

If you do this five days a week, that is £750 per week from morning sessions alone. £3,000 per month. Before your evening sessions.

The e-bike is not a lifestyle choice. It is an income infrastructure decision.

The Kit Setup

The right e-bike setup for a London mobile PT:

- Mid-range e-bike with a rear rack. Budget £800–£1,500 for something reliable secondhand (Cowboy, Raleigh, or a quality conversion).

- A quality rear rack bag — at least 20 litres. This holds your mat (rolled and strapped), bands, timer, gloves and pads, a suspension trainer, and your personal kit.
- Panniers or a secondary bag for clothing layers and client paperwork.
- A quality lock (Kryptonite or Hiplok). Budget £70–£100. Not negotiable in London.
- Theft insurance (Laka or Bikmo — approximately £10–£15/month).

The total investment is approximately £1,000–£1,700. The return on that investment — in saved transport costs alone — is achieved within three to five months.

After that, every pound you save on transport goes directly into profit.

Part Two: The All-Weather Protocol

Training in the Rain Is Your Marketing Strategy

I want to revisit that Tuesday morning in November from the prologue.

When I was cycling through the rain to my 6:00 AM session, two other PTs I know had already messaged cancellations to their clients. By 7:00 AM, there would be three or four more in the

same WhatsApp group.

By 9:00 AM, I had completed three sessions in full.

This is not about toughness for its own sake.

It is about understanding what your clients actually value.

When a client books an outdoor PT session, they are not just buying exercise. They are buying commitment. Accountability. The presence of a professional who will show up regardless of circumstances. A client who trains with you in November rain builds a different kind of loyalty than a client who trains with you in June sun. They have a story to tell. They tell that story to their friends.

That story is your marketing.

The trainers who cancel in bad weather are inadvertently advertising their unreliability. The trainer who doesn't cancel is advertising exactly the opposite.

There is, however, a caveat.

You can only deliver on the all-weather promise if you are actually equipped for all weather. Showing up soaking, shivering, and clearly miserable is not professional. It does not inspire confidence. It tells your client that you have not thought through your own working conditions.

The all-weather mindset requires the all-weather kit.

The Mandatory Waterproof Kit

This is not a "nice to have" list. This is the baseline for outdoor work in a London winter.

Gore-Tex shoes (or equivalent fully waterproof trail shoes — Salomon, Merrell, or Inov-8 waterproof range).

Why: Standing on wet grass for sixty minutes in running shoes that are merely "water resistant" leaves you with soaked feet by minute fifteen. Wet feet affect your movement, your posture, your focus, and your mood. You cannot project confidence and authority while visibly uncomfortable in your own body. Waterproof shoes are a professional tool.

Fully waterproof jacket (seam-sealed, Gore-Tex or equivalent — not a "softshell").

Why: Softshell jackets are water-resistant. They handle drizzle for thirty minutes. In sustained London rain, they fail. A seam-sealed waterproof jacket keeps you dry for an entire session. It also looks professional — a structured waterproof jacket looks significantly better on a trainer than a sodden softshell.

Waterproof overtrousers.

Why: Nobody looks at a trainer's legs during a session. But a trainer who is drenched from the waist down is distracted, cold, and counting down to the session ending. Waterproof overtrousers take sixty seconds to put on. Keep them in your rack bag permanently.

Total cost of the above three items (quality, mid-range brands): £200–£350. One-off purchase. Lasts three to five years with care.

This is not a discretionary expense. It is the cost of being able to do your job in a country where it rains approximately one hundred and fifty days per year.

The Essential Kit List

Mat. Non-slip, at least 6mm thick. Used for warm-ups, cool-downs, floor work, and stretching. Wet grass requires a mat with grip. A cheap mat that slides on damp ground is a liability, not a tool.

Resistance bands (light, medium, heavy). Three bands that fit in a pouch. Between them, they provide progressive resistance for almost every exercise pattern. They weigh almost nothing. There is no excuse for not having all three.

Suspension trainer (TRX or equivalent). A full bodyweight training system that attaches to any fixed point — a tree, a fence post, a goalpost. Unlocks pull-based exercises you cannot replicate with bands alone. It is the single most versatile piece of kit per unit of weight available.

Jump rope. A five-minute jump rope circuit replaces a treadmill warm-up. Clients who cannot skip learn. The learning curve is part of the engagement.

Interval timer. Structure signals professionalism. A session without intervals — without defined work periods, rest periods, and transitions — is exercise. A session with them is training. This distinction matters to your clients more than you might think.

Boxing pads and gloves. This deserves a dedicated section.

Why Boxing Is Your Ice-Breaker

New clients are nervous.

They are nervous because they are unfamiliar with you, with outdoor training, with the format. They are often embarrassed about their fitness level. They may have had a negative gym experience in the past. They are performing in public, in a park, where other people might see them.

Boxing removes all of that.

When you put pads on your hands and tell a client to throw a jab — even a tentative, slightly wrong, first-time jab — something changes. They laugh. They try again. The awkwardness of "I'm working out with a stranger in a park" evaporates, replaced by the very simple, very human experience of hitting something and finding it satisfying.

By the time you move into the structured session, the client is warm, relaxed, and enjoying themselves.

Enjoyment drives retention.

And here is the business case: a client who finishes their first session having laughed, moved explosively, and genuinely had fun tells people about it. A client who finishes their first session having done squats, lunges, and a plank — even excellent squats, lunges, and a plank — tells fewer people about it, because the story is not as vivid.

The gloves and pads are a referral engine. They cost £25–£40. The return on that investment is immeasurable.

Cold Weather Protocols

In temperatures below 10°C (standard London October through March), adjust as follows:

Dynamic warm-up minimum: **eight minutes**, not five. Cold muscles in cold air take longer to reach a safe operating temperature. This is not optional. One pulled hamstring in a January session is one lost client, one bad review, and one expensive lesson.

Rest periods: shortened by 30%. Longer rests in cold weather allow core temperature to drop. A client standing still in January air for sixty seconds after an intense set gets cold very quickly. Keep transitions brisk and purposeful.

Layering: Your clients should arrive dressed to train — warm base layer, mid-layer, windproof shell. Remind them of this in your session reminder the night before. A cold client is an un-

comfortable client. An uncomfortable client is a client who starts questioning whether outdoor training is right for them.

Know your covered backup. For every session location, identify one covered space within a three-minute walk. A café with an overhang. A bandstand. A covered market entrance. Rain that is genuinely too heavy to train in — standing water, lightning — happens rarely, but it happens. Having a specific backup is the difference between a professional who adapts and a trainer who apologises.

Part Three: Park Rules — Where You Can and Cannot Train

The One Rule That Ends Careers Early

There is a category of mistake that new mobile PTs make that is not about fitness, not about business, and not about money.

It is a geography mistake.

And it can cost you a client session, a repeat booking, and in some cases your professional reputation in a single fifteen-minute encounter.

Do not train clients commercially in a Royal Park without a permit.

The eight Royal Parks — Hyde Park, Kensington Gardens, St James's Park, The Green Park, Regent's Park, Primrose Hill, Greenwich Park, Richmond Park and Bushy Park — are Crown land. They are not managed by local councils. They have their own officers, their own rules, and their own enforcement.

Commercial personal training in a Royal Park without a written, paid permit is unauthorised. If a Royal Parks Officer observes you training a client and identifies the relationship as commercial — which they are trained to do, and which is not difficult to establish — you will be asked to stop.

That is the best-case scenario.

The worst-case scenario involves a formal notice, a ban from the park, and the very uncomfortable experience of being removed in front of your client.

That is not a conversation that ends with the client rebooking.

The permit process exists but is competitive, geographically capped, and expensive. Most independent PTs cannot practically obtain one in the short term. The practical solution is simple: do not build your business around Royal Park locations.

Where You Can Train

The majority of London's green spaces are not Royal Parks.

They are managed by one of the thirty-two London boroughs, or by the City of London Corporation, or by the GLA, or by private landowners.

The enforcement of commercial PT restrictions in council-managed parks varies enormously — from very strict to entirely non-existent. In the majority of cases, a mobile trainer working with one client in a local park, without permanent equipment, without blocking public access, and without amplified music, will not be challenged.

However — and this is important — operating without checking is operating on assumption. Assumptions create risk.

The ten-minute solution:

Email your local borough's parks department. Ask one question: *"Do you have any restrictions on commercial personal training within council-managed parks in the borough?"*

Get the answer in writing.

If the answer is that commercial PT is permitted, you have written confirmation. If the answer is that it requires a permit, you now know the process.

This email takes ten minutes. The protection it provides is indefinite.

Practical operating principles for any public space:

Do not occupy the same spot long enough to suggest permanence. Move around within the space between exercises.

Do not anchor equipment to park infrastructure without permission. Suspension trainers attached to trees are generally fine. Anything that could be interpreted as a permanent installation is not.

Do not use amplified music without confirming it is permitted in that space. Many parks have specific regulations on this.

Leave the space exactly as you found it. You may need to return tomorrow. Your continued access depends on the relationship you have — explicitly or implicitly — with the space and the community that uses it.

Approved partner locations:

If you are working with **Ourparks** in any capacity, the spaces they have approved for use through their platform have pre-negotiated access agreements. This is part of the genuine value they offer to early-stage mobile PTs. Using their approved locations removes the guesswork about where you can operate.

Chapter Two Summary: The London-proof strategy runs on three pillars — e-bike logistics that compress travel time and cost, an all-weather protocol that makes your business weather-independent, and a clear map of where you can operate without risk. Master all three and you have an infrastructure that most trainers never build.

Chapter Three — The Freedom Math

Why self-employment is the only model that actually scales

The Comparison Nobody Makes Explicit

Let me put two scenarios in front of you.

Scenario A: Gym Floor PT

- Licence fee: £350/month
- Average sessions per month (realistic, after 6 months): 22
- Average rate: £45/session
- Gross income: £990
- Minus licence: £640
- Travel costs (tube, zone 1–2): £180
- Net monthly income: £460
- Hours in the building (floor shifts + sessions): approximately 180 hours
- Effective hourly rate: £2.56

Scenario B: Independent Mobile PT (12 months in)

- Monthly sessions: 40

- Average rate: £55/session (premium for 1:1 outdoor convenience)
- Gross income: £2,200
- Transport (e-bike costs): £30
- Equipment/insurance: £40
- Professional memberships/insurance: £30
- Net monthly income: £2,100
- Hours worked (sessions + admin + travel): approximately 70 hours
- Effective hourly rate: £30

The gym floor PT is making £2.56 an hour.

The mobile PT is making £30 an hour.

And the mobile PT is working *fewer hours*.

These are not theoretical numbers. They are conservative estimates based on realistic scenarios. The gym floor numbers err on the generous side. The mobile numbers are achievable within twelve months by a trainer who follows the model outlined in this book.

The gap is not small. It is not a marginal improvement. It is more than ten times the effective hourly rate for less than half the hours.

This is the freedom math.

The Scaling Problem with Employment

Here is the fundamental constraint of every employed or semi-employed PT model:

Your income is capped by someone else's ceiling.

In a gym chain, your income ceiling is set by the licence fee structure, the gym's pricing guidelines for PT sessions, and the volume of clients you can physically fit into the hours you are permitted to operate.

In a studio partnership, your income ceiling is set by the percentage split, the studio's booking capacity, and the rate they charge clients.

In a PT agency or instructor role, your income ceiling is set by what the agency charges their clients and what percentage they pass to you.

In every case, there is a ceiling. And it is not yours to raise.

The only model with no ceiling — or at least, no externally imposed ceiling — is full self-employment. Your sessions, your rates, your clients, your schedule.

The ceiling in that model is your time. And time is a constraint you can address through group sessions, pair training, online programming, and — eventually — other revenue streams. But none of those options are available to you if you are spending your time on someone else's floor at someone else's rate.

The Two Platforms Worth Your Time

I am not going to pretend that jumping from zero to forty self-employed sessions per month is instantaneous. It isn't. Building a client base takes time, and the early stages of that process are genuinely difficult.

There are two platforms that can legitimately accelerate the early stage without trapping you in a long-term dependency.

Ourparks

Ourparks connects mobile and outdoor PTs with clients across London. It handles some of the visibility and marketing work that you cannot yet do yourself because you do not have the brand, the reviews, or the reach.

What it does well: Gives you access to clients you would not otherwise reach. Provides a trusted platform context that reduces the barrier for a potential client to book with someone they have never met. Has pre-negotiated access agreements with park spaces that removes location risk.

What it does not do: Give you ownership of the client relationship. Create brand recognition for you specifically. Scale infinitely — the platform takes a fee on every session.

How to use it: Join. Operate professionally. Use the reviews you generate to build your direct reputation. Convert clients to direct booking once the exclusivity clause in your agreement ex-

pires (check the specific terms). Do not build your entire business on this platform indefinitely.

Motivate PT

Motivate PT operates at a slightly different level — the leads they generate tend to be of higher value and higher commitment. Corporate clients, higher-budget individuals, and clients who are looking for premium outdoor training.

What it does well: Accelerates your exposure to the quality of client that you want to be working with long-term. The leads come qualified — these are people who have already decided they want PT and are selecting between providers, not people who are idly browsing.

What it costs: A fee structure that reduces your per-session margin. Worth paying temporarily; not worth paying permanently.

How to use it: As a lead generation tool with an active conversion strategy. The objective is to turn Motivate PT leads into direct clients over time. A client who came through Motivate PT initially but books directly with you after the first twelve-week block is a direct client. Treat every Motivate PT session as an audition for that conversion.

The Fully Independent Model

Once you have five to eight direct clients paying you consistently, you have something platforms cannot take from you: a client base built on personal relationship and demonstrated results.

At this point, your growth strategy shifts.

Referrals become your primary acquisition channel. A client who has trained with you for twelve weeks and achieved results is a marketing asset. The four-week review conversation, the eight-week check-in, the progress video — these are not just good service. They are systematic referral triggers. A client who sees measurable results and tells you about them at week eight is a client who is about to tell someone else.

Reviews compound. Five Google reviews attract a sixth client. A sixth client becomes a seventh review. The compounding effect of consistent five-star reviews on a Google Business Profile is slow in the beginning and then very fast. The trainers who do not have a Google Business Profile set up — with their specific service area, their specialisms, their contact details, and a stream of current reviews — are invisible to a significant proportion of London's search-driven client acquisition.

Set yours up. Keep it current. Ask for a review at week four of every client relationship. Not at the end of a twelve-week block. At week four, when enthusiasm is highest.

Your rate scales because your credibility scales. A trainer with twenty reviews and two years of documented results charges £65/session, not £45. Not because the session itself is dramatically different, but because the credibility infrastructure around it is dramatically different. The price you charge is not just a fee — it is a signal. And the signal a higher rate sends, when backed by evidence, is that you are worth it.

The Pair Training Multiplier

One of the most powerful, most underused tools in the independent mobile PT toolkit is the pair session.

Two clients. Same time. Same location.

You charge each client 80% of your solo rate. They pay less. You earn 60% more per hour than you do in a solo session. Both clients benefit from the dynamic of training with a partner — accountability, competition, fun.

The pair session model works particularly well in the morning commuter slot, where two friends or colleagues who live near each other can combine a social session with a training commitment.

It works well as a referral mechanism — invite a client to bring a friend for a discounted pair session. The friend becomes a solo client six weeks later.

It works well for NHS and key worker discounts — two nurses, two teachers, two colleagues, booking together. This is the discount structure that feels most generous to the client while having the least impact on your per-hour rate.

If you have twelve solo clients at three sessions per month, you have thirty-six sessions per month. If six of those clients pair up, you have twenty-four sessions serving twelve clients — at 80% of your rate each. Your per-hour income increases. Your travel decreases. Your satisfaction, because the pair sessions tend to be the most energetic, tends to increase too.

Build this into your offering from the start.

Chapter Three Summary: The freedom math is simple: self-employment delivers ten times the effective hourly rate of a gym floor role at less than half the hours. Platforms like Ourparks and Motivate PT are legitimate bridges to use temporarily and deliberately. The long-term model is direct clients, compounding reviews, and pair session leverage.

Chapter Four — The System

Training is only half the business. This is the other half.

The Part Nobody Teaches You

Your Level 3 qualification taught you how to train clients.

It taught you movement assessment, programming principles, nutrition fundamentals, client communication, and health screening. It gave you the technical foundation to make someone fitter, stronger, leaner, or more mobile.

It did not teach you how to run a business.

This is not a criticism of the qualification. The qualification does what it says it does. The business education is simply not part of it.

But the trainers who fail — who burn out, who lose clients they should have kept, who work more than they earn, who never quite build the momentum they expected — almost always fail on the business side, not the training side.

They are excellent coaches and mediocre operators.

This chapter is about the operations.

The Financial System

Rule One: Never Accept Cash

I want to be clear about the reason for this, because some trainers push back initially.

It is not primarily about tax — though tax compliance is obviously important. It is about professionalism and boundary-setting.

Cash transactions blur the commercial relationship. When a client hands you £45 in notes at the end of a session, the financial exchange feels informal. It feels personal. The psychological contract it creates is different from the one created when a bank transfer notification arrives with your client's reference code.

Cash also creates practical problems.

You cannot send an invoice for cash. You cannot easily track sessions paid versus sessions owed when transactions are informal. You cannot accept cash remotely, which means a client who wants to prepay for a block of sessions has to physically give you an envelope.

Bank transfer or card payment only. Make this clear in your terms and conditions before the first session. Clients who push back on this are telling you something useful about how they handle financial commitments.

Rule Two: Prepayment Is Mandatory

Trainers who do not require prepayment have a cancellation problem.

The reason is psychological. When a client has already paid for a session, cancelling it costs them something tangible — a session they have purchased that they will not receive. When a client has not paid in advance, cancelling a session costs them nothing at the moment of cancellation. The cost feels theoretical.

Prepayment shifts this dynamic. The session has already been purchased. Showing up feels like using something you own. Not showing up feels like throwing money away.

Implement prepayment as a block booking model: clients purchase sessions in blocks of four, six, or ten. They pay in advance. Sessions are then scheduled from that block.

This also transforms your cash flow. Instead of receiving income session by session, you receive it block by block — a larger amount, less frequently. This makes budgeting and financial planning dramatically simpler.

Rule Three: The 24-Hour Cancellation Policy Exists to Be Enforced

Every trainer has a cancellation policy. Very few enforce it consistently.

The reason they don't enforce it is understandable. Enforcing a cancellation policy feels confrontational. It feels like putting money above the relationship. It creates an awkward moment.

What trainers who don't enforce their policy consistently fail to appreciate is the long-term cost of not enforcing it.

A client who knows you will waive the cancellation charge will begin to treat your time as optional. The 24-hour cancellation window becomes 12 hours. Then same-day. Then "I just woke up and I'm not feeling it, is that okay?" The sessions become less reliable, the income becomes less predictable, and the relationship shifts from professional to casual.

State your policy clearly at the start. *"My cancellation policy is twenty-four hours. A session cancelled after that window is charged in full. If you need to cancel with more than twenty-four hours' notice, we'll rebook. If it's inside that window, the session is deducted from your block."*

Say it once. Write it in your terms and conditions. Sign those terms with the client. And then enforce it consistently, from the very first time.

The clients who challenge this policy most vigorously are often the ones who cancel most frequently. Enforcing the policy does not damage the relationship with clients who value your time. It identifies the clients who don't, and redirects your energy accordingly.

The Client Management System

The Forms You Cannot Skip

This is a business critical section. Not because it is exciting — it is not — but because the absence of these forms creates legal exposure that can end a career.

PAR-Q (Physical Activity Readiness Questionnaire)

Completed by every client before any physical activity. Identifies cardiovascular risk factors, musculoskeletal concerns, and contraindications to vigorous exercise.

If a client answers YES to any PAR-Q question, you are required to obtain written medical clearance before proceeding with training. This is not a guideline. It is an industry standard and, in the context of a negligence claim, the difference between a defensible position and an indefensible one.

Health Screening Form

More detailed than the PAR-Q. Covers medical history, current medications, previous injuries, surgeries, and lifestyle factors including sleep, stress, and nutrition. This forms your programming brief and your liability documentation simultaneously.

Informed Consent and Liability Waiver

The client acknowledges, in writing, that they understand the physical demands of training and the inherent risk of exercise. This does not eliminate your duty of care — you are still profes-

sionally obligated to train them appropriately, to apply your qualifications, and to respond correctly to any incident. But it establishes the client's informed participation and significantly changes the legal context of any dispute.

Goal-Setting and Enquiry Form

What are they training for? What is their timeline? What is their training history? What injuries or limitations are relevant? What is their schedule and their budget? This information drives your programming and your client conversations. Without it, you are guessing.

Progress Photo and Video Consent Form

Explicit written consent to capture images or video of the client, and clear definition of how those images may be used — publicly, privately, or not at all. Never post an image or video of a client without this form signed. The privacy implications of doing so are serious, and the professional damage of a client publicly objecting to their image being used is irreversible.

Terms, Conditions, and Cancellation Policy

A single document that covers: your rates, your cancellation policy, your payment terms, your refund position, your professional standards, and the expectations of both parties. Signed before the first paid session. Enforced consistently.

Keep all of these forms digitally. Google Drive, a dedicated folder, password-protected. Paper forms get damaged, lost, or become illegible. A digital record is accessible anywhere, searchable, and

defensible in any dispute.

The Scheduling System

The 5:30 AM and 7:00 PM Principle

The most valuable time slots in mobile PT are the 5:30 AM and 7:00 PM slots.

Not because you particularly want to be awake at 5:00 AM. Because your clients' lives dictate these slots, and the clients who book them are the most reliable, committed, and long-term.

The 5:30 AM client is a professional. They are at work by 8:30 or 9:00 AM. The only time training fits in their day is before work starts. They book the slot because nothing else competes with it. The kids are not awake yet. Their phone is not buzzing yet. Their calendar is clear.

This client cancels less than any other demographic, because the alternative — training at lunch or after work — is genuinely worse for them. The 5:30 AM slot is their solution, not a compromise.

The 7:00 PM client is also a professional. They leave work between 6:00 and 6:30 PM, travel thirty to forty-five minutes, and arrive at a park near their home with enough daylight (in summer) or willingness (in winter) to train. They book this slot because it is the logical end to their day.

The midday client — the 10:00 AM or 12:00 PM booking — is valuable when they are consistent. But the midday demographic skews toward people between jobs, freelancers with flexible schedules, or retirees. These groups have more scheduling volatility. Cancellations are more frequent. When their circumstances change — when they return to work, when their freelance project picks up, when their health changes — the midday session is the first thing to go.

Build your core business around the 5:30 AM and 7:00 PM anchors. Fill the gaps with midday clients, but do not structure your income around them.

The Geographic Clustering Strategy

Every hour you spend travelling between clients is an hour you are not earning.

The solution is to cluster clients by geography. Three clients within a fifteen-minute e-bike radius of each other, scheduled consecutively, means less than thirty minutes of travel for three sessions of income.

When you acquire a new client, before you confirm the booking, check the map. Where do your existing clients train? Where does this new client live or want to train? Is there a scheduling window that allows you to place them in a cluster?

This is not always possible. Sometimes a great client exists in isolation and the session is worth the extra travel. But as a structural principle, geographic clustering is the difference between earning £750 before 9:00 AM and spending that same time earning £350 while covering significantly more ground.

Build your target zones deliberately. Pick two or three geographic areas within your operating radius where you want to build client density. Focus your marketing — your Google Business Profile, your local park presence, your word-of-mouth push — on those zones.

The Marketing System

Who You Are Talking To

Marketing your PT business is not about becoming an Instagram influencer. It is about becoming visible to the right people, in the right places, at the right moment.

The right people, for a mobile PT in London, are professionals between twenty-five and fifty, predominantly female, who are already fitness-minded but who are either not making progress with their current approach or who do not have a current approach.

They are not looking for a PT who trains like a competitive athlete. They are looking for someone who can help them build consistency, show them results, and make the process feel achievable and even enjoyable.

Your marketing should speak to that.

The Google Business Profile

Set this up immediately if you have not already done so.

A complete Google Business Profile — with your service area, your specialisms, your contact details, your photos, and a steady stream of current reviews — makes you visible in "personal trainer near me" searches. This is free. It is local. It is the highest-converting form of digital marketing available to a mobile PT.

The review acquisition strategy is simple: at week four of every client relationship, ask directly. Not an automated email. Not a text. In conversation, at the end of a session. *"You've been making great progress. If you've got a moment, a Google review would genuinely help me a lot. I can send you the link directly."*

Week four is the optimal moment. Early enough that the enthusiasm is still high. Late enough that there are tangible results to point to.

The Progress Video

At weeks four, eight, and twelve, record a short video of the client in motion. With their explicit written consent from the consent form signed at intake.

This video serves three purposes.

For the client: it is objective evidence of progress. The thing that looks qualitative — "I feel fitter, I move better" — becomes quantitative when they watch themselves performing an exercise at week twelve versus the same exercise at week one.

For your marketing: it is specific, authentic, real-world social proof. Not a posed photograph. Not a staged before/after. A genuine clip of a real client doing real work and getting better.

For the relationship: it shows the client that you are tracking them. That you are paying attention. That you see their progress even when they do not see it themselves. Clients who feel seen and tracked stay longer than clients who feel like they are just showing up for a workout.

The Growth System

Referrals Are Your Acquisition Engine

After twelve months of building direct clients, the majority of your new business will come from referrals if you have done the job properly. A client who has trained with you for twelve weeks and achieved results is not just a retained client. They are a marketing asset.

The conditions that produce referrals are: results, relationship, and a prompt.

Results come from good programming and consistency.

Relationship comes from the kind of trainer you are — present, communicative, invested in the person, not just the session.

The prompt is the one thing most trainers do not add, even when the first two conditions are satisfied.

At week eight of every client relationship, have a direct conversation. *"You've made a lot of progress. Do you know anyone else who might benefit from working with me? I've got a couple of slots coming up."*

This is not aggressive. It is honest. Your clients like you. They want to help you. They just need to know you are looking for referrals. The prompt removes the ambiguity.

The NHS and Key Worker Discount

A ten to fifteen percent discount for NHS staff, teachers, paramedics, firefighters, and police is both ethically correct and commercially strategic.

These communities talk to each other constantly. A staff room, a hospital ward, a fire station — these are tight social networks. One NHS physiotherapist who trains with you and has a great experience will mention your name to three or four colleagues within a month. If one of those colleagues books, you have acquired a new client at the cost of a 15% discount on one client's monthly sessions.

Advertise this discount explicitly on your Google Business Profile and any social media you maintain.

The Block Booking Incentive

Ten sessions prepaid at a ten percent discount.

This works for three reasons.

It improves your cash flow — you receive payment for ten sessions before you have delivered any of them.

It improves client retention — a client who has purchased ten sessions has a reason to see those sessions through. Commitment follows investment.

It simplifies your admin — you know your forward revenue for the next eight weeks.

Offer block booking as the default to every client after their first four sessions. Position it as a saving, not a demand.

Chapter Four Summary: The system is what separates trainers who build businesses from trainers who have jobs. Financial discipline, client management processes, geographic scheduling, and a deliberate referral and growth strategy transform an excellent training practice into a scalable, sustainable business.

Chapter Five — The Call to Action

Skip the years of trial and error

What I Spent Three Years Learning

I want to be direct with you about something.

Everything in this book took me time to figure out.

The gym floor model — I did it. I understand it from the inside. The unpaid hours, the rent-clawback quarters, the sessions I completed and the income I kept that felt disproportionate to the effort. I have stood in the position you are in now, or the position you are trying to avoid.

The e-bike revelation did not happen immediately. I spent months on public transport, showing up late, missing potential morning slots because the commute did not allow back-to-back sessions. The maths became obvious only after I experienced the alternative.

The all-weather protocol evolved through trial and error — through sessions I was underprepared for, clients who cancelled because I had not set the right expectations, gear that failed in ways I should have anticipated.

The client intake forms, the cancellation policy, the block booking structure, the referral conversation — all of it was developed through situations where the absence of a system created a problem.

A cancellation policy that was not enforced, until I learned why it had to be.

A client who injured themselves mildly, and the gratitude I felt for having a signed PAR-Q and consent form.

A referral that happened because I asked, that I would not have received if I had waited for it to happen spontaneously.

This book condenses what I learned across three years into the time it takes to read it. That is its value — not that the information is secret or proprietary, but that it is organised, honest, and directly actionable.

But a book can only take you so far.

The Gap Between Knowing and Having

Reading about a client intake system and having a client intake system are different things.

Reading about an outreach email template and having one, tested and ready to deploy, is different.

Understanding the concept of a business management dashboard and actually having one running on your own device — ready to open, ready to use — is different.

Knowledge is the first step. The implementation is the step most people do not take, because the implementation requires:

Time they do not have.

Technical skills they may not possess.

The discipline to do it before they feel ready, not after.

The trainers who build successful mobile businesses quickly are not the ones who know the most. They are the ones who execute most efficiently. They do not spend six months building forms and systems from scratch. They start with what works, refine it, and spend their energy training clients rather than designing spreadsheets.

The Mobile PT Business-in-a-Box

Everything I have built to run my mobile PT business — the documents, the templates, the outreach tools, the management dashboard — is available as a complete bundle.

Not a PDF with generic advice. The actual operational infrastructure.

What's included:

The Client Intake Pack

All six mandatory forms — PAR-Q, Health Screening, Informed Consent and Liability Waiver, Goal-Setting and Enquiry Form, Progress Photo/Video Consent, and Terms, Conditions, and Cancellation Policy — professionally written, legally considered, and ready to send.

These are not templates you need to rewrite. They are documents you can brand with your name, your rates, and your policies, and start using immediately.

The Outreach Email Templates

Two outreach templates — Local Business outreach (for corporate wellness enquiries and local business partnerships) and Individual Client outreach — that have been refined through actual use. Subject lines, opening paragraphs, body copy, and closing. Designed to generate responses, not to sound like marketing emails.

The Enquiry Form

A client-facing digital enquiry form that captures name, phone, email, goal, availability, and training history. Saves directly to the app. Designed to be shared as a link — by text, by social media, by Google Business Profile — so prospective clients can register interest without having to phone or email first.

The Business Management Dashboard

A standalone desktop app (Mac and Windows) that shows your client enquiries, outreach history, and lead pipeline. Your data saves directly to your device — no subscriptions, no cloud account, no technical setup required. Open it on your laptop, run it from your desktop. Everything stays private and local.

The Prospect Tracker

A built-in tracker where you log every lead you encounter — park conversations, referrals, social media contacts, platform enquiries — and move them through your pipeline from first contact to converted client. One place for everything. No spreadsheet juggling.

The PT Operations Playbook

An interactive mobile-first checklist of every business rule, every protocol, and every daily operational non-negotiable — formatted so that you can review it in ninety seconds on your phone before your first session of the day.

This is the infrastructure I wish I had when I started.

Not the information — the actual tools, documents, and systems. The difference between knowing you need a PAR-Q and having a PAR-Q that is ready to send. The difference between understanding outreach and having an outreach template that works.

The bundle is available at:

[YOUR GUMROAD LINK HERE]

If you are at the beginning of your mobile PT journey, this bundle removes the months of trial and error that most trainers go through to build these systems.

If you are already running a mobile PT business but have not formalised your operations — no signed client forms, no cancellation policy enforcement, no outreach process — this gives you the professional infrastructure you need to protect your business and grow it.

If you are currently on a gym floor and planning your exit, this gives you the client management and outreach tools you need to launch your independent operation before you leave.

What This Is Not

This is not a course. There are no modules to complete, no assignments to submit, no community to join.

This is an operational toolkit. You use what you need. You start using it the day you download it.

Some of the tools will be immediately relevant. Others become relevant as your business grows. The document pack is useful from day one. The outreach tools become more valuable once you are actively building your client pipeline. The dashboard becomes more valuable once you have enough client movement to track.

The price reflects what these tools are worth — not what the cheapest version of them would look like, but what a professional-grade operational infrastructure delivers in time saved, clients retained, and income protected.

Epilogue: The Only Question That Matters

There is a moment that every mobile PT has, usually in the first winter.

It is dark when you wake up. It is cold. Your 5:30 AM client has not cancelled yet but you are convinced they are about to. The park is going to be wet. Your kit bag is heavy. The duvet is not heavy. The duvet is exactly right.

In that moment, you face the only question that actually matters in this industry:

Are you going to do it anyway?

Not because it is comfortable. Not because it is easy. Not because you are guaranteed to be rewarded for it. But because you chose this. Because the alternative — the gym floor, the 12-hour shift, the rent clawback, the slowly suffocating ceiling — is worse than the rain.

Because there is a client on the other side of that alarm who chose you. Who is setting their own alarm right now. Who is going to arrive at that park and look for you, and the moment they see you there — prepared, warm in your Gore-Tex, pads out and ready — they are going to know that they made the right choice.

That moment is the business.

Not the Instagram post about it. Not the five-star review they give you later. The moment itself — the professional showing up in conditions that would stop most people — is what the mobile PT business is built on.

Everything in this book — the logistics, the systems, the financial model, the forms — those are the scaffolding.

The foundation is this:

You go anyway.

And then you build from there.

The Mobile PT Business-in-a-Box bundle — templates, forms, dashboard, outreach tools, and play-book — is available at:

[YOUR GUMROAD LINK HERE]

Use the code

MANIFESTO

at checkout for a launch discount.

About the Author

Dean Burt is a mobile personal trainer based in London. He specialises in outdoor, one-to-one and pair training for professionals who want results without the gym. He built his training business from zero — no gym floor, no platform dependency — using the model outlined in this book.

The **Mobile PT Business-in-a-Box** bundle is available at the link above.

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The Mobile PT Manifesto

First Edition

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